UNIT I

MODERN SOCIOLOGICAL THEORIES

FUNCTIONALIST PERSPECTIVES

Meaning of Sociological Theory

Sociological theory is a systematic set of concepts and propositions used to understand, explain and interpret social life. It helps sociologists move beyond individual events and identify broader patterns in social relationships, institutions and social change.

Theory connects **concepts, explanations and evidence**. It may explain why societies remain stable, why conflict occurs, how individuals interact, or how social institutions change.

Nature of Sociological Theory

Sociological theory is:

- **Systematic:** It organizes ideas and concepts logically.
- **Explanatory:** It seeks to explain social relationships and processes.
- **Abstract:** It deals with concepts such as social structure, norms, power, status and institutions.
- **Empirical:** Good sociological theories can be examined in relation to social evidence.
- **Interpretive or critical:** Some theories focus on understanding meanings, while others examine inequality, power and social change.
- **Dynamic:** Theories may be modified when new social conditions or evidence emerge.

Major Types of Sociological Theory

Sociological theories can be broadly understood as:

Type	Main Concern
Macro theory	Large-scale social structures, institutions and social systems
Micro theory	Everyday interaction and individual social behaviour
Grand theory	Broad explanations of society as a whole
Middle-range theory	Specific social phenomena that can be connected to empirical research

Type	Main Concern
Functional theory	Social order, stability and functions of institutions
Conflict theory	Inequality, power and social conflict
Interactionist theory	Meaning and everyday interaction
Critical theory	Domination, ideology and possibilities of social change

I-B. Talcott Parsons — Social Action

Introduction

Talcott Parsons developed one of the most influential forms of structural functionalism. He viewed society as a system of interconnected parts in which social action is guided by norms and values.

Social Action

For Parsons, action involves an **actor, a goal, a situation and normative values**. Human behaviour is therefore not simply biological or random; it is shaped by social expectations.

For example, a student attending a university class acts toward a goal—education or obtaining a degree—but this action is also influenced by rules, expectations and values concerning education.

Parsons emphasised that social action is **voluntary but normatively oriented**. Individuals have choices, but those choices operate within a system of social norms and values.

Social System

When individual actions become organised through shared norms and expectations, they form patterns of interaction and contribute to a **social system**. Institutions such as family, education, religion and government help maintain these patterns.

Critical Perspective

Parsons has been criticised for giving greater importance to **social order and stability** than to conflict, inequality and rapid social change. His approach may also underestimate individual creativity and resistance.

Key Points

- Action is goal-oriented and socially guided.
- Norms and values influence behaviour.
- Social actions become organised into social systems.

- Shared values are important for social order.

I-C. Talcott Parsons — Pattern Variables

Meaning

Pattern variables are a set of five pairs of contrasting orientations that Parsons used to explain choices individuals make while performing social roles.

Pattern Variable	First Orientation	Second Orientation
Affectivity vs Affective Neutrality	Emotional involvement	Emotional restraint
Self-orientation vs Collectivity-orientation	Personal interest	Group interest
Universalism vs Particularism	General rules	Special relationships
Achievement vs Ascription	Status based on performance	Status based on assigned qualities
Specificity vs Diffuseness	Limited role relationship	Broad relationship

Example

A doctor treating a patient is generally expected to follow **universalistic and specific** standards rather than allowing personal friendship to determine professional decisions. In contrast, family relationships may involve particularistic and diffuse expectations.

Pattern variables therefore help Parsons explain how social roles differ across institutions and societies.

Critical Perspective

The model can appear too rigid because real social relationships often combine both sides of these alternatives. Modern societies also contain diverse roles that cannot always be neatly classified.

I-D. Parsons — Functional Prerequisites of the Social System

Meaning

Parsons argued that every social system must perform certain basic functions if it is to survive and maintain a degree of stability. These are commonly expressed through the **AGIL model**.

AGIL Model

Function	Meaning	Example
A — Adaptation	Obtaining and distributing resources	Economy
G — Goal Attainment	Defining and achieving collective goals	Political system
I — Integration	Coordinating different parts of society	Law and social norms
L — Latency / Pattern Maintenance	Maintaining values and motivating members	Family and education

Application

For example, during an economic crisis, the economic system must adapt to changing conditions, political institutions must establish goals, legal institutions must maintain coordination, and family and educational institutions help transmit values and expectations.

Critical Perspective

AGIL provides a useful framework for examining how institutions contribute to social order. However, it tends to emphasise **system needs and equilibrium** and may understate conflict, unequal power and institutional dysfunction.

The AGIL model explains the basic requirements through which a social system maintains itself:

Adaptation → Goal Attainment → Integration → Latency

I-E. Robert K. Merton — Functional Analysis

Introduction

Robert K. Merton revised structural functionalism by making it more flexible and empirically oriented. He argued that sociologists should examine the actual consequences of social practices rather than assuming that every institution is beneficial.

Manifest and Latent Functions

- **Manifest functions** are intended and recognised consequences of an action or institution.
- **Latent functions** are unintended or less recognised consequences.

Example: Education has the manifest function of providing knowledge and qualifications. A latent function may be creating friendships, social networks and peer groups.

Dysfunction

Merton also introduced the idea of **dysfunctions**—consequences that reduce the adjustment or stability of a social system.

For example, an examination system may select students for further education, but excessive competition may also create stress and inequality.

Functional Alternatives

Merton recognised that the same social function may be performed by different institutions or practices. Therefore, one particular institution should not automatically be treated as indispensable.

Critical Perspective

Merton's approach is more flexible than Parsons because it recognises **dysfunction, unintended consequences and functional alternatives**. However, functional analysis can still give insufficient attention to power and conflict.

Manifest functions = intended consequences
Latent functions = unintended consequences
Dysfunctions = harmful or disruptive consequences

I-F. Robert K. Merton — Reference Group

Meaning

A **reference group** is a group that individuals use as a standard for evaluating their attitudes, behaviour, status or achievements, whether or not they are actual members of that group.

People may compare themselves with groups they belong to or groups they aspire to join.

Types and Functions

A reference group can serve as:

- A **standard of comparison** for judging one's own position.
- A **normative influence** that shapes values and behaviour.
- An **aspirational model** for individuals who want to become part of a particular social group.

Example

A university student may compare their academic performance, lifestyle or career ambitions with a group of successful professionals or high-achieving students. That group becomes a reference point even if the student is not a member of it.

Critical Perspective

Reference-group theory is useful for understanding **social comparison, aspirations and relative evaluation**. However, individuals may have multiple reference groups, and their choices are also influenced by wider structures such as class, gender and economic opportunities.

Reference groups help explain how people evaluate themselves and develop aspirations through **social comparison**.

I-G. Robert K. Merton — Middle-Range Theories

Meaning

Merton proposed **middle-range theories** as a way of avoiding the limitations of both highly abstract grand theories and purely descriptive empirical research.

A middle-range theory focuses on a **limited but important range of social phenomena** and connects theoretical concepts with empirical investigation.

Examples

Merton's work on:

- reference groups,
- anomie,
- bureaucracy,
- social roles, and
- unintended consequences

illustrates the middle-range approach.

Importance

Middle-range theories are useful because they are:

- sufficiently theoretical to explain social patterns,
- sufficiently specific to be tested through research,
- adaptable to different social contexts.

Critical Perspective

Middle-range theory provides a practical balance between theory and research. However, critics argue that focusing on limited phenomena may make it difficult to develop a comprehensive explanation of society.

Merton's central contribution: sociological theory should be **theoretically meaningful and empirically testable**.

I-H. Jeffrey Alexander — Neo-Functionalism

Introduction

Jeffrey C. Alexander developed **neo-functionalism** as an attempt to reconstruct and extend functionalist theory rather than simply reject it.

He argued that functionalism could remain useful if it paid greater attention to **culture, social action, conflict, differentiation and social change**.

Main Features of Neo-Functionalism

Alexander's neo-functionalism:

- retains an interest in social order and social systems;
- gives greater importance to **culture and meaning**;
- recognises social conflict and change;
- connects individual action with larger social structures;
- avoids treating society as a completely harmonious system.

Application

In analysing education, a traditional functionalist approach may focus mainly on how education contributes to social integration and socialisation. A neo-functionalist approach would also examine **cultural meanings, inequality, conflict and changing expectations** within educational institutions.

Critical Perspective

Neo-functionalism broadened functionalist theory and made it more responsive to criticisms of Parsons. However, critics argue that it still retains a strong concern with social order and may not give sufficient importance to radical conflict and structural inequality.

Key Points

Alexander's neo-functionalism attempts to make functionalism:

more flexible + more cultural + more dynamic + more attentive to action and conflict.

I-I. Comparative Understanding

Thinker	Main Contribution	Central Concepts
Talcott Parsons	System and social order	Social Action, Pattern Variables, AGIL
Robert K. Merton	Revision of functionalism	Manifest/Latent Functions, Dysfunction, Reference Groups, Middle-Range Theory
Jeffrey Alexander	Reconstruction of functionalism	Neo-functionalism, Culture, Action, Social Change

Parsons and Merton

Parsons developed a broad theory of social systems and emphasised **order, integration and shared values**. Merton made functionalism more empirically oriented by introducing **manifest and latent functions, dysfunctions and functional alternatives**.

Merton and Alexander

Merton made functionalism more flexible and research-oriented, while Alexander further reconstructed it by incorporating **culture, action, conflict and social change**.

Overall Development

Parsons → Merton → Alexander

Grand functional theory → Empirical and flexible functional analysis → Neo-functionalism

I-J. Overall Critical Perspective

Functionalism made an important contribution by showing how social institutions are interconnected and how norms, values and institutions contribute to the organisation of society. Parsons provided a comprehensive theory of social systems, while Merton introduced greater flexibility and empirical sensitivity. Alexander attempted to update functionalism for modern sociology.

However, functionalism has been criticised for giving too much importance to **stability, consensus and integration**. It may underestimate social conflict, inequality, domination and the possibility that institutions benefit some groups more than others.

I-K. Overall Unit Summary

This unit introduces the functionalist tradition and its development from Parsons to Merton and Alexander.

- **Parsons** explains social action and the functioning of social systems through norms, values and the AGIL model.
- **Pattern variables** explain different orientations that guide social roles.
- **Merton** revises functionalism through manifest and latent functions, dysfunctions and functional alternatives.
- **Reference group theory** explains how people evaluate themselves through comparison with others.
- **Middle-range theory** connects sociological concepts with empirical research.
- **Alexander** develops neo-functionalism by incorporating culture, action, conflict and social change.

In simple terms:

Parsons asks: How does society maintain order?
Merton asks: What are the actual and unintended consequences of social institutions?
Alexander asks: How can functionalism be reconstructed to better explain culture, action and change?

Central theme of Unit I:
Society is an interconnected system, but understanding it requires attention not only to order and integration but also to unintended consequences, conflict, culture and change.

UNIT I

1. **Discuss Talcott Parsons' theory of social action. Explain the role of norms, values, pattern variables, and the social system in regulating human behaviour.**

2. **Examine Parsons' structural-functional approach to society. Discuss the functional prerequisites of the social system and their significance in maintaining social order.**

3. **Critically examine Robert K. Merton's contribution to functional analysis. Discuss manifest functions, latent functions, dysfunctions, and non-functions with suitable examples.**

4. **Discuss Merton's concept of middle-range theories. How did Merton attempt to bridge the gap between grand sociological theories and empirical research?**

5. **Compare the functional theories of Talcott Parsons and Robert K. Merton. Discuss their similarities, differences, and contributions to modern sociological thought.**

UNIT II

1. Introduction

Louis Althusser (1918–1990) was a French Marxist philosopher whose work contributed significantly to **structural Marxism**. He attempted to reinterpret Marxism by moving away from explanations that reduced society primarily to economic relations or individual actions.

For Althusser, society consists of interconnected structures that shape the conditions within which individuals and groups act.

2. Structural Marxism

Althusser rejected a simple interpretation in which the economic structure directly determines every aspect of social life. He viewed society as a complex **social formation** consisting of relatively distinct but interconnected levels, particularly the economic, political and ideological levels.

The economic structure remains fundamental, but political and ideological structures possess a degree of **relative autonomy**. They cannot simply be understood as direct reflections of the economy.

Thus, society should be understood as a complex relationship among different structures rather than as a simple one-way relationship between the economic base and everything else.

3. Reproduction of Social Relations

A central question for Althusser is:

How does a social system reproduce itself over time?

Capitalism requires not only the production of goods but also the reproduction of the social relations necessary for production. Workers must acquire skills, discipline and appropriate forms of behaviour, while the wider population must become familiar with the norms and values of the existing social order.

Institutions such as education, family and religion contribute to this process of reproduction.

4. Repressive State Apparatuses

Althusser distinguishes between **Repressive State Apparatuses (RSAs)** and **Ideological State Apparatuses (ISAs)**.

Repressive State Apparatuses operate primarily through coercion or the threat of coercion. They include institutions such as the police, courts, prisons, military and state administration.

Their role is to help maintain the existing social order through direct or potential force.

5. Ideological State Apparatuses

Ideological State Apparatuses operate primarily through ideology rather than direct coercion. Althusser identifies institutions such as education, family, religion, media and cultural institutions as important ideological apparatuses.

These institutions help reproduce social relations by shaping people's beliefs, values and ways of understanding the social world.

The distinction can therefore be expressed simply as:

RSA → primarily coercion

ISA → primarily ideology

In practice, however, institutions can involve both coercive and ideological mechanisms.

6. Interpellation

Interpellation refers to the process through which ideology constitutes individuals as particular kinds of social subjects. People come to recognise themselves within socially defined roles and identities.

For example, institutions may encourage individuals to understand themselves as students, workers, citizens, consumers or members of particular social groups.

Through such processes, individuals participate in existing social relationships without necessarily experiencing them as forms of external control.

7. Application

The education system provides a useful example. From an Althusserian perspective, education does more than provide knowledge and skills. It also teaches discipline, punctuality, accepted forms of behaviour, ideas about achievement and appropriate social roles.

Education may therefore contribute to the **reproduction of existing social relations**.

8. Critical Perspective

Althusser's structural Marxism has been criticised for giving insufficient attention to human agency and making individuals appear overly shaped by structures and ideology. It can also make resistance and social transformation difficult to explain.

Nevertheless, his contribution is important because he showed that domination is reproduced not only through economic relations and direct coercion but also through **institutions, ideology and the formation of social subjects**.

Key Points

Althusser's structural Marxism emphasises the relationship between economic, political and ideological structures. His concepts of **Repressive State Apparatuses, Ideological State Apparatuses and interpellation** explain how existing social relations are reproduced.

II-B. ANTONIO GRAMSCI — HEGEMONY

1. Introduction

Antonio Gramsci (1891–1937) was an Italian Marxist thinker whose work expanded Marxist analysis of power, culture and ideology. His most influential concept is **hegemony**.

Gramsci was particularly concerned with understanding why subordinate groups may accept or participate in a social order that does not necessarily serve their interests.

2. Meaning of Hegemony

Hegemony refers to the process through which a dominant group maintains leadership by securing a significant degree of **consent** from subordinate groups.

Power therefore operates through both:

Coercion + Consent

A ruling group does not have to depend entirely on force. It can also influence how people understand what is normal, natural, legitimate and desirable.

3. Hegemony and Common Sense

Gramsci gave particular importance to **common sense**.

Dominant ideas become powerful when they appear to be ordinary and natural rather than the product of particular historical and social conditions.

Ideas about success, merit, authority, gender roles, social status or economic behaviour may therefore be accepted as “common sense” even though they reflect particular social arrangements and interests.

Hegemony operates partly through this organisation of meaning.

4. Civil Society and Political Society

Gramsci distinguishes between **political society** and **civil society**.

Political society refers more directly to institutions associated with governmental authority and coercion, such as the state, police and courts.

Civil society includes institutions through which ideas, values and consent are produced and contested, such as schools, family, religion, media, associations and cultural organisations.

Civil society is therefore an important arena in the struggle for **hegemony**.

5. Intellectuals

Gramsci considered intellectuals important in the production and transformation of social consciousness.

Traditional intellectuals tend to see themselves as relatively independent from particular social classes.

Organic intellectuals emerge in connection with particular social groups and help express and organise their experiences, interests and worldviews.

Organic intellectuals can contribute either to the reproduction of existing hegemony or to the development of alternative forms of consciousness.

6. War of Position and War of Manoeuvre

Gramsci used these concepts to understand struggles for social transformation.

A **war of manoeuvre** refers to a more direct confrontation with political power, whereas a **war of position** refers to a prolonged struggle within civil society to develop cultural, intellectual and organisational influence.

In complex modern societies, the struggle for social transformation cannot be reduced to capturing the state. It also involves challenging established ideas and forms of cultural authority.

7. Application

Media and popular culture can be examined through a Gramscian perspective by asking: Whose ideas are presented as normal? Which lifestyles are represented as desirable? Whose voices receive legitimacy? How are dominant values reproduced? Where do alternative ideas and forms of resistance emerge?

The focus is therefore not simply on who controls an institution, but also on **how consent and meaning are produced**.

8. Critical Perspective

Gramsci's concept of hegemony is valuable because it explains why domination cannot be understood only through economic power or physical coercion. However, the concept can become broad and difficult to define precisely. There is also continuing debate about the relative importance of material interests, culture, ideology and political organisation.

Its major contribution is the recognition that **power operates through culture and consent as well as coercion**.

Key Points

Gramsci's theory shifts attention from domination through force to domination through **consent, culture and common sense**. Civil society becomes a major arena in which hegemony is both reproduced and challenged.

II-C. RALF DAHRENDORF — CLASS AND CLASS CONFLICT IN INDUSTRIAL SOCIETY

1. Introduction

Ralf Dahrendorf (1929–2009) developed a conflict-oriented theory partly in response to both **Marxism and functionalism**.

He argued that conflict is a normal and continuing feature of modern society. While Marx focused strongly on ownership and economic class, Dahrendorf placed greater emphasis on **authority and power within social organisations**.

2. Conflict and Social Structure

Dahrendorf argued that society contains both **integration and conflict**.

Functionalist theories tend to emphasise consensus and social integration, whereas conflict perspectives emphasise inequality, competing interests and power.

For Dahrendorf, conflict is not an abnormal condition. It arises from the structure of social relationships themselves.

3. Authority

Authority is central to Dahrendorf's theory.

Authority refers to the socially recognised right to issue commands and expect compliance. It is attached to **social positions**, rather than simply to individual personalities.

For example, managers possess authority over workers, administrators over subordinates and officials over citizens within particular institutional settings.

Where authority is unequally distributed, different positions tend to have different interests.

4. Imperatively Coordinated Associations

Dahrendorf uses the term **imperatively coordinated associations** for organisations in which social positions are arranged through authority relationships.

Examples include factories, schools, government departments and bureaucratic organisations.

Within these organisations, some positions exercise authority while others are subject to it. This creates the structural basis for conflict.

5. Class Conflict

For Dahrendorf, classes emerge from **authority relationships**.

Those who occupy positions of authority and those who are subject to authority have potentially opposing interests.

Conflict can therefore emerge between:

Dominant positions → authority

and

Subordinate positions → lack of authority

This approach extends class analysis beyond ownership of the means of production.

6. Quasi-Groups, Interest Groups and Conflict Groups

Dahrendorf distinguishes different stages in the development of conflict.

A **quasi-group** consists of people who occupy similar structural positions and may have common interests without being organised.

An **interest group** emerges when people become conscious of shared interests and begin to organise.

A **conflict group** is an organised group that actively pursues its interests against another group.

Thus:

Structural position → shared interests → organisation → conflict

7. Conflict and Social Change

Conflict can produce social change by altering authority relationships, institutional arrangements and organisational rules.

For example, workplace conflict between management and workers may lead to negotiations, changes in working conditions, new rules or redistribution of authority.

Conflict is therefore not simply destructive. It can become a source of **institutional transformation**.

8. Dahrendorf and Marx

Dahrendorf shares Marx's emphasis on conflict but differs in the basis of class analysis.

Marx	Dahrendorf
Emphasis on economic class and ownership	Emphasis on authority
Class linked strongly to means of production	Class linked to authority positions

Marx	Dahrendorf
Focus on capitalism and historical transformation	Focus on conflict within modern organisations
Major emphasis on economic relations	Conflict can arise in many authority relationships

Dahrendorf therefore broadened conflict theory by showing that authority relations exist beyond the traditional capitalist ownership relationship.

9. Critical Perspective

Dahrendorf's theory has been criticised for reducing class conflict too strongly to authority relations and giving insufficient attention to economic ownership, exploitation and broader forms of inequality.

It also does not fully explain why people occupying similar structural positions always do not develop collective organisations.

Nevertheless, his contribution is significant because it demonstrates that **authority relations throughout modern organisations can generate structured conflict**.

Key Points

Dahrendorf explains conflict through unequal **authority relations**. People occupying different authority positions may have opposing interests, and organised conflict can produce changes in institutions and social relationships.

II-D. LEWIS COSER — FUNCTIONS OF SOCIAL CONFLICT

1. Introduction

Lewis A. Coser (1913–2003) developed a theory of conflict that combined insights from conflict theory and functionalism.

His major work, *The Functions of Social Conflict*, challenged the assumption that conflict is necessarily destructive.

His central question was:

Can conflict perform positive functions for groups and social systems?

2. Meaning of Social Conflict

Social conflict involves struggles over values, status, power, resources or interests.

Coser argued that conflict can have different consequences. It may be destructive, but under certain conditions it can also contribute to group integration, adaptation and social change.

3. Functions of Conflict

Conflict can strengthen group boundaries by distinguishing one group from another. External conflict may also increase internal solidarity because members unite in response to a common threat.

Conflict can clarify group norms by making members more conscious of shared values and acceptable behaviour. It can also bring hidden tensions into the open and provide an outlet for accumulated grievances.

At the wider social level, conflict may reveal weaknesses in existing arrangements and create pressure for reform and institutional adjustment.

Thus, conflict can contribute to **social adaptation and change**.

4. Realistic and Non-realistic Conflict

Coser distinguishes between **realistic** and **non-realistic conflict**.

Realistic conflict arises from specific competing interests and is directed towards achieving a particular objective. A dispute over wages or working conditions is an example.

Non-realistic conflict may arise primarily from the need to release tension or hostility rather than from a specific practical objective.

This distinction shows that conflicts can have different origins and consequences.

5. Internal and External Conflict

Conflict within a group may expose tensions, clarify norms and encourage organisational adjustment.

Conflict between groups may strengthen group boundaries and solidarity.

However, excessive or uncontrolled conflict can have the opposite effect and lead to fragmentation or organisational breakdown.

Coser therefore does not suggest that **all conflict is beneficial**.

6. Application

Consider a student organisation in which members disagree about leadership, priorities or the use of resources.

If the disagreement is managed constructively, conflict may clarify organisational goals, improve decision-making and expose problems that require attention.

If the conflict becomes intense and persistent, however, it may divide members and weaken the organisation.

The consequences of conflict therefore depend upon its **context, intensity and management**.

7. Critical Perspective

Coser's approach is valuable because it challenges the simple assumption that consensus is always beneficial and conflict is always harmful.

However, not all conflicts produce positive outcomes. The effects of conflict depend upon the nature of the relationship, the degree of inequality, the intensity of the conflict and the resources available to the groups involved.

Coser's major contribution is therefore to examine the **functions and consequences of conflict**, rather than treating conflict as inherently destructive.

Key Points

Coser shows that conflict can have both **destructive and constructive consequences**. It may strengthen solidarity, clarify norms, release tensions and encourage social change, although excessive conflict can also weaken groups and institutions.

II-E. COMPARATIVE UNDERSTANDING

The four thinkers examine conflict from different but complementary perspectives.

Thinker	Central concern	Key concept
Althusser	Reproduction of social relations	Ideological State Apparatuses
Gramsci	Cultural domination and consent	Hegemony
Dahrendorf	Authority and structured conflict	Authority
Coser	Consequences and functions of conflict	Functions of conflict

Althusser focuses primarily on **structures and ideology**, explaining how existing social relations are reproduced. Gramsci extends this analysis by showing how domination also depends upon **consent and cultural leadership**. Dahrendorf shifts attention towards **authority relations within organisations** and the interests generated by them. Coser moves further towards analysing what conflict itself does to groups and social systems.

II-F. OVERALL CRITICAL PERSPECTIVE

Conflict perspectives have made an important contribution by directing sociological attention towards **power, inequality, domination, competing interests and social change**.

At the same time, conflict theories can sometimes overemphasise division and underestimate the importance of consensus, cooperation and shared values. They also need to explain why unequal social arrangements sometimes remain stable for long periods.

Contemporary conflict analysis must also recognise that inequality is not limited to class. **Class, caste, gender, ethnicity, race, status and institutional position** can interact in complex ways.

Conflict perspectives are therefore most useful when they are used not simply to identify disagreement but to examine **who possesses power, how power is maintained, whose interests are served, how resistance develops and what consequences conflict produces**.

II-G. OVERALL UNIT SUMMARY

Conflict perspectives challenge approaches that explain society mainly through consensus, integration and stability. They emphasise the role of **power, inequality, domination, competing interests and conflict** in shaping social relationships and institutions.

Louis Althusser developed structural Marxism and explained the reproduction of social relations through interconnected economic, political and ideological structures. His distinction between **Repressive State Apparatuses and Ideological State Apparatuses** shows how social order is maintained through both coercion and ideology.

Antonio Gramsci developed the concept of **hegemony** to explain how dominant groups maintain power partly through consent. His analysis of civil society, common sense and intellectuals demonstrates that cultural and ideological struggles are central to the maintenance and transformation of power.

Ralf Dahrendorf shifted the focus of conflict theory towards **authority relations**. Modern organisations contain positions of authority and subordination, creating different interests and the potential for organised conflict. Conflict can consequently become an important source of institutional change.

Lewis Coser examined the **functions of social conflict**. He demonstrated that conflict is not necessarily destructive and can strengthen group solidarity, clarify norms, release tensions and promote adaptation and change, although conflict can also have destructive consequences.

The four perspectives can therefore be remembered as:

Althusser — Structure and Ideology
Gramsci — Hegemony and Consent
Dahrendorf — Authority and Class Conflict
Coser — Functions and Consequences of Conflict

Together, these perspectives provide different ways of understanding **how power operates, how domination is maintained, how conflict emerges and how conflict can contribute to social transformation**.

UNIT- II

Q1. Discuss Antonio Gramsci's concept of cultural hegemony. Explain how consent, civil society, intellectuals, and ideology contribute to the maintenance of social domination.

Q2. Critically examine Louis Althusser's structural Marxism. Discuss the role of Repressive State Apparatuses and Ideological State Apparatuses in reproducing capitalist society.

Q3. Explain Ralf Dahrendorf's theory of class conflict. Discuss the relationship between authority, power, social positions, and conflict in modern industrial society.

Q4. Compare Marx's theory of class conflict with Dahrendorf's conflict theory. How does Dahrendorf modify the Marxist understanding of class and social change?

Q5. Examine the relationship between ideology, power and social control in the theories of Gramsci and Althusser. How do their approaches explain the reproduction of existing social structures?

UNIT III

Interactionist Perspectives

Unit Focus

This unit examines sociological perspectives that focus on **everyday interaction, subjective meaning and the construction of social reality**. It moves from George Herbert Mead's theory of the **self**, through Goffman's analysis of everyday presentation, Alfred Schutz's phenomenology and Garfinkel's ethnomethodology, to Berger and Luckmann's theory of the **social construction of reality**.

The central concern is:

How do individuals create, interpret and maintain social reality through everyday interaction?

III-A. G.H. MEAD — MIND, SELF AND SOCIETY

1. Introduction

George Herbert Mead (1863–1931) was an American philosopher and social theorist whose ideas became an important foundation for **symbolic interactionism**.

Mead argued that the human self does not develop in isolation. It emerges through **social interaction, communication and the use of symbols**.

His major ideas concerning **mind, self and society** are closely interconnected.

2. Mind

For Mead, the **mind** develops through social interaction. It is not simply something that exists independently within an individual.

Language and significant symbols allow people to communicate, interpret situations and think about their own actions.

The ability to take the role of others is therefore essential to the development of the mind.

3. Self

The **self** develops when individuals become capable of seeing themselves from the perspective of others.

A person learns to ask:

How do others see me?

How would others expect me to behave?

The self therefore develops through social experience.

Mead distinguishes between the **“I” and the “Me.”**

The “I”

The “I” represents the spontaneous, creative and relatively unpredictable aspect of the self.

The “Me”

The “Me” represents the organised attitudes and expectations of others that an individual has internalized.

The self emerges through the interaction between the **“I” and the “Me.”**

4. Role-Taking

Role-taking is the ability to imagine a situation from another person's perspective.

For example, a child gradually learns to understand how a parent, teacher or friend expects them to behave.

Role-taking enables individuals to participate effectively in social interaction.

5. Play Stage and Game Stage

Mead explains the development of the self through stages of social experience.

In the **play stage**, children learn to take the role of particular others, such as a parent, teacher or doctor.

In the **game stage**, children learn to understand several roles simultaneously and recognize the expectations of others involved in a structured activity.

This leads to the development of the **generalized other**.

6. Generalized Other

The **generalized other** refers to the broader community's attitudes, expectations and rules that individuals internalise.

It allows individuals to understand what is generally expected of them as members of society.

Thus:

Interaction → Role-taking → Internalisation of expectations → Development of self

7. Application

A student entering university gradually learns:

- how students are expected to behave;
- how teachers expect students to behave;
- what constitutes acceptable academic conduct;
- how other students evaluate behaviour.

Through these interactions, the student develops a sense of self appropriate to the social setting.

8. Critical Perspective

Mead's theory is important for explaining how the self develops socially, but it has limitations. It gives relatively greater attention to interaction and meaning than to large-scale structures such as class, caste, economic inequality and institutional power.

Nevertheless, Mead established an important foundation for understanding the **social nature of the self and human identity**.

Key Points

Mead argues that **mind, self and society develop through social interaction**. The concepts of the **"I," "Me," role-taking and generalized other** are central to his explanation of the development of the self.

III-B. ERVING GOFFMAN — PRESENTATION OF SELF IN EVERYDAY LIFE

1. Introduction

Erving Goffman (1922–1982) developed a distinctive approach to everyday interaction. His major work, *The Presentation of Self in Everyday Life*, uses a **dramaturgical perspective** to examine how individuals manage their behaviour and presentation before others.

Goffman compares everyday social interaction with a **theatrical performance**.

2. Dramaturgical Perspective

According to Goffman, people present themselves differently in different social situations.

Individuals attempt to influence how others perceive them by managing:

- appearance;

- speech;
- behaviour;
- surroundings;
- expressions.

Social interaction therefore involves a degree of **impression management**.

3. Front Stage and Back Stage

Front Stage

The **front stage** is the setting in which individuals perform roles before an audience and follow the expectations associated with the situation.

For example, a teacher in a classroom performs according to expectations concerning professionalism and authority.

Back Stage

The **back stage** is a setting where individuals can relax their public performance and prepare for interaction.

The same teacher may behave very differently among close friends or colleagues.

4. Impression Management

Impression management refers to the ways individuals attempt to control the impressions others form of them.

People may carefully manage:

- clothing;
- language;
- facial expressions;
- gestures;
- physical surroundings;
- information about themselves.

This does not necessarily mean that people are deliberately “fake.” Rather, social interaction requires individuals to manage how they present themselves in particular situations.

5. Teams

Goffman also discusses **performance teams**.

A team consists of individuals who cooperate in maintaining a shared definition of a situation.

For example, staff members in a restaurant may cooperate to present a particular experience to customers, even though their behaviour outside the workplace may be different.

6. Application

A job interview provides a simple example.

The candidate carefully manages:

- clothing;
- language;
- body posture;
- answers;
- expressions;
- information presented to the interviewer.

The interviewer also manages their own presentation.

Both participants are therefore involved in **impression management**.

7. Critical Perspective

Goffman's approach provides a powerful analysis of everyday interaction, but it has been criticised for focusing heavily on face-to-face situations and paying less attention to wider structures of power, inequality and history.

It can also make social life appear excessively theatrical.

Nevertheless, Goffman demonstrated that everyday interaction involves **rules, expectations, performances and management of impressions**.

Key Points

Goffman's dramaturgical approach explains everyday interaction through concepts such as **front stage, back stage, impression management and performance teams**.

III-C. ALFRED SCHUTZ — THE PHENOMENOLOGY OF THE SOCIAL WORLD

1. Introduction

Alfred Schutz (1899–1959) developed a phenomenological approach to sociology. His major concern was understanding how individuals experience and interpret the **social world of everyday life**.

Schutz was strongly influenced by phenomenological philosophy, particularly the work of **Edmund Husserl**.

2. The Lifeworld

The **lifeworld** refers to the everyday world that individuals experience as familiar, meaningful and taken for granted.

People normally do not question every aspect of their everyday surroundings. They rely on accumulated knowledge to navigate social situations.

For example, when entering a classroom, students generally understand what a classroom is, what a teacher is expected to do and how students are expected to behave.

3. Stock of Knowledge

Individuals possess a **stock of knowledge** built through previous experiences and socialisation.

This knowledge helps people interpret new situations.

It includes:

- practical knowledge;
- cultural understandings;
- social expectations;
- classifications;
- routines.

Individuals use this knowledge to make sense of everyday life.

4. Typification

People understand the social world through **typifications**.

A typification is a generalised understanding or category used to interpret people, situations and events.

For example, people have ideas about what constitutes a “teacher,” “student,” “doctor” or “police officer.”

These typifications make everyday interaction possible because people do not have to understand every situation from the beginning.

5. Intersubjectivity

Intersubjectivity refers to the shared understanding that makes social interaction possible.

Although individuals have their own subjective experiences, they are able to assume that others inhabit a common social world.

Communication depends upon this shared understanding.

6. Application

When students enter a classroom, they generally share assumptions about:

- the meaning of “class”;
- the role of the teacher;
- appropriate student behaviour;
- how teaching and learning should occur.

Much of this knowledge is not explicitly explained each time. It is part of the participants' **stock of knowledge**.

7. Critical Perspective

Phenomenology provides a detailed understanding of subjective experience and everyday meaning, but it may pay less attention to large-scale structures, material inequality and institutional power.

Its major contribution is to demonstrate that social reality is not simply an external structure. It is also a world that people **experience, interpret and make meaningful in everyday life**.

Schutz focuses on the **lifeworld, stock of knowledge, typification and intersubjectivity**. His approach explains how individuals make sense of the everyday social world.

III-D. HAROLD GARFINKEL — ETHNOMETHODOLOGY

1. Introduction

Harold Garfinkel (1917–2011) developed **ethnomethodology**, an approach concerned with the methods people use to produce and understand social order in everyday situations.

The term refers broadly to the study of the everyday methods through which people make their social world intelligible.

2. Basic Idea

Garfinkel argued that social order is not simply something imposed from outside. People actively produce and maintain a sense of order through their everyday interactions.

Individuals use shared assumptions, practical knowledge and conversational practices to make situations understandable.

3. Indexicality

Indexicality means that the meaning of an expression depends partly on its context.

For example, statements such as:

“I'll meet you there later.”

cannot be fully understood without knowing what “there” and “later” refer to.

Everyday communication therefore depends upon contextual knowledge.

4. Reflexivity

Reflexivity refers to the way social actions and descriptions help produce and reinforce the social reality they describe.

People's accounts of situations are not simply descriptions of reality; they can also contribute to making the situation appear orderly and meaningful.

5. Breaching Experiments

Garfinkel became well known for **breaching experiments**, in which taken-for-granted expectations are deliberately disrupted in order to reveal the hidden assumptions underlying everyday interaction.

For example, if familiar everyday rules are unexpectedly violated, people often demand explanations because the normal assumptions of interaction have been disturbed.

The purpose is not simply to create confusion but to reveal the **background expectations through which social order is produced**.

6. Application

Consider an ordinary queue.

People generally understand:

- where the queue begins;
- who is next;
- what counts as “cutting” the queue;
- how people should wait.

Most of these rules are not formally written down. Yet people recognize violations immediately.

Ethnomethodology examines the practical methods through which people produce and maintain this kind of everyday order.

7. Critical Perspective

Ethnomethodology provides a detailed account of everyday social practices, but critics argue that its strong focus on interaction can understate the influence of larger structures such as class, state institutions and economic inequality.

Its major contribution is to show that social order is **actively accomplished in everyday life**, rather than simply existing independently of social actors.

Key Points

Garfinkel's ethnomethodology studies the everyday methods through which people produce social order. **Indexicality, reflexivity and breaching experiments** are central concepts.

III-E. PETER BERGER AND THOMAS LUCKMANN — THE SOCIAL CONSTRUCTION OF REALITY

1. Introduction

Peter L. Berger (1929–2017) and Thomas Luckmann (1927–2016) developed an influential sociological approach to the construction of everyday reality in their book *The Social Construction of Reality*.

Their central argument is that what people experience as social reality is produced and maintained through **human interaction, institutionalization and shared meanings**.

2. Social Reality

People experience society as something external and objective. However, Berger and Luckmann argue that social reality is historically produced through human activity.

People create patterns of behavior, institutions and meanings. These creations then become established and appear objective to later generations.

Thus:

Human activity → social patterns → institutionalization → objective reality

---

3. Externalisation

Externalization refers to the process through which human beings produce social forms and meanings through their activities.

People create rules, practices, institutions and meanings.

For example, repeated ways of organising work can gradually become established organizational practices.

4. Objectivation

Objectivation occurs when humanly produced social arrangements come to appear as objective, independent realities.

People may forget that institutions and social practices were historically created by human beings and begin to experience them as simply “the way things are.”

5. Internalization

Internalization occurs when individuals learn and absorb the social reality of their society.

Through socialisation, people acquire:

- norms;
- values;
- roles;
- meanings;
- institutional expectations.

They therefore come to experience socially created realities as personally meaningful and normal.

6. The Social Construction Process

The three processes can be summarised as:

Externalisation → Objectivation → Internalisation

People create social reality.

↓

Their creations become established and appear objective.

↓

Individuals internalise these realities through socialisation.

This creates a continuing relationship between **individuals and society**.

7. Institutionalisation

Repeated patterns of behavior can become institutionalized.

For example, if people repeatedly organize teaching according to established roles, rules and routines, these practices may become institutionalized as the **education system**.

Institutions then confront individuals as established social realities.

8. Socialisation

Berger and Luckmann distinguish between **primary socialisation** and **secondary socialisation**.

Primary socialisation

Occurs mainly during childhood and introduces individuals to the basic world of their society.

Secondary socialisation

Occurs later as individuals enter specific institutional and occupational worlds.

Through socialisation, people acquire the knowledge necessary to function within different social settings.

9. Application

Consider the institution of **education**.

People historically create practices concerning:

- teachers;
- students;
- examinations;
- classrooms;
- qualifications.

Over time these practices become institutionalised. New students encounter them as established realities and learn how to behave through socialisation.

Education therefore illustrates how humanly created practices can become **objective social institutions**.

10. Critical Perspective

The social construction approach is valuable because it demonstrates that many aspects of social reality are historically and socially produced rather than simply natural or inevitable.

However, critics may argue that an excessive focus on construction can understate material conditions and structural constraints. Not everything individuals experience can be changed simply through changing meanings.

The approach is nevertheless important for understanding the relationship between **individual agency, social institutions and shared meanings**.

Key Points

Berger and Luckmann explain social reality through **externalisation, objectivation and internalisation**. Institutions are historically produced through human activity and subsequently become objective realities that individuals encounter and internalise.

III-F. COMPARATIVE UNDERSTANDING

Thinker	Central concern	Key concepts
G.H. Mead	Development of self through interaction	Mind, Self, I, Me, Generalized Other
Erving Goffman	Everyday presentation and interaction	Dramaturgy, Front Stage, Back Stage, Impression Management
Alfred Schutz	Meaning of everyday social world	Lifeworld, Stock of Knowledge, Typification, Intersubjectivity

Thinker	Central concern	Key concepts
Harold Garfinkel	Production of everyday social order	Ethnomethodology, Indexicality, Reflexivity, Breaching
Berger & Luckmann	Construction and institutionalisation of reality	Externalisation, Objectivation, Internalisation

These perspectives share an interest in **everyday social life**, but they approach it differently.

Mead focuses on how interaction contributes to the development of the **self**. Goffman examines how individuals manage their presentation during everyday encounters. Schutz explores how individuals experience and interpret the **lifeworld**. Garfinkel examines the practical methods through which people produce a sense of social order. Berger and Luckmann connect everyday interaction with the broader process through which social reality becomes **institutionalised and internalised**.

III-G. OVERALL CRITICAL PERSPECTIVE

Interactionist and phenomenological perspectives have made an important contribution by shifting sociological attention towards **meaning, interaction, interpretation and everyday experience**.

They challenge approaches that treat society only as an external structure acting upon individuals. Instead, they show that social reality is continuously interpreted, negotiated and reproduced through everyday activity.

However, these approaches have also been criticised for giving insufficient attention to large-scale structures such as **class, caste, gender, economic inequality, political power and the state**. A focus on everyday interaction can sometimes make broader structural constraints less visible.

Their major contribution lies in demonstrating that society is not simply something that exists "above" individuals. Social reality is also continually **produced and reproduced through human interaction and shared meanings**.

III-H. OVERALL UNIT SUMMARY

Interactionist perspectives focus on the **micro-level processes through which individuals interpret, construct and maintain social reality**.

G.H. Mead explains the development of mind and self through social interaction. His concepts of the **"I," "Me," role-taking and generalized other** demonstrate how the self emerges within society.

Erving Goffman analyses everyday interaction through a **dramaturgical perspective**. Concepts such as front stage, back stage and impression management explain how individuals present themselves and manage social situations.

Alfred Schutz examines the subjective experience of the **social world**. His concepts of the lifeworld, stock of knowledge, typification and intersubjectivity explain how people interpret everyday reality.

Harold Garfinkel developed **ethnomethodology**, which examines the practical methods through which people produce and maintain everyday social order. Indexicality, reflexivity and breaching experiments reveal the taken-for-granted assumptions underlying ordinary interaction.

Peter Berger and Thomas Luckmann connect everyday interaction with the institutional production of social reality. Their concepts of **externalisation, objectivation and internalisation** explain how humanly created patterns become established institutions and are subsequently internalised by individuals.

The five perspectives can therefore be remembered as:

Mead — Development of the Self
Goffman — Presentation of Self
Schutz — Experience of the Lifeworld
Garfinkel — Production of Everyday Order
Berger & Luckmann — Social Construction of Reality

Together, these perspectives demonstrate that to understand society, sociology must examine not only institutions and structures but also **how people create meaning, interpret situations and construct social reality in everyday life**.

UNIT III

1. **Discuss George Herbert Mead's theory of Mind, Self and Society. Explain the development of the self through social interaction, including the concepts of the "I," "Me," play, game, and generalized other.**
2. **Examine Erving Goffman's dramaturgical approach to social interaction. Discuss presentation of self, impression management, front stage, back stage, and role performance.**
3. **Discuss the concept of self and identity in the theories of George Herbert Mead and Erving Goffman. Highlight the similarities and differences between their approaches.**
4. **Explain Harold Garfinkel's concept of ethnomethodology. Discuss how individuals create and maintain social order through everyday interactions and practical reasoning.**
5. **Critically examine the interactionist perspective on everyday social life. Discuss how social reality, identity, roles, and meanings are constructed through everyday interaction.**

UNIT IV

Contemporary Sociological Perspectives

JÜRGEN HABERMAS — PUBLIC SPHERE AND COMMUNICATIVE ACTION

1. Introduction

Jürgen Habermas (1929–2026) is a major German social theorist associated with the **Frankfurt School** and critical theory.

His work addresses questions of **communication, rationality, democracy and social integration**. Two important concepts are the **public sphere** and **communicative action**.

2. Public Sphere

The **public sphere** is a social space in which private individuals come together to discuss matters of common or public concern.

Historically, Habermas associated the development of the modern public sphere with spaces such as:

- coffee houses;
- salons;
- newspapers;
- associations;
- other forums of public discussion.

The ideal public sphere is based on **open, rational and critical discussion** rather than status or coercion.

3. Characteristics of the Public Sphere

An effective public sphere requires:

- access to public discussion;
- freedom of expression;
- exchange of arguments;
- critical debate;

- relative equality among participants.

The public sphere can therefore contribute to **democratic participation and the formation of public opinion**.

4. Communicative Action

Habermas distinguishes **communicative action** from action oriented primarily towards individual success or strategic advantage.

Communicative action occurs when individuals seek to reach **mutual understanding through communication**.

For example, two people discussing a disagreement and attempting to arrive at a mutually acceptable understanding are engaged in communicative interaction.

Communication becomes socially important because people coordinate their actions through shared understanding.

5. Communicative Rationality

Habermas argues that communication contains the possibility of **rational agreement**.

Participants can question whether statements are:

- factually valid;
- normatively appropriate;
- sincerely expressed.

Communication is therefore not simply the exchange of information; it can also provide a basis for critically examining social norms and claims to authority.

6. System and Lifeworld

Habermas distinguishes between the **system** and the **lifeworld**.

The lifeworld refers to the shared cultural meanings, values and everyday understandings through which people communicate.

The system refers primarily to institutional mechanisms such as the **economy and state**, which operate through mechanisms such as money and administrative power.

Habermas is concerned about the **colonisation of the lifeworld**, where economic and administrative mechanisms increasingly influence areas of everyday life that should ideally be organised through communication and shared understanding.

7. Application

Social media can be considered a contemporary public space because it enables individuals to discuss political and social issues. However, unequal access, misinformation, commercial interests, algorithms and polarisation can affect the quality of public debate.

Thus, the existence of a communication platform does not automatically guarantee an effective public sphere.

8. Critical Perspective

Habermas's theory has been criticised for presenting an overly idealised model of rational public discussion. Historically, many groups—particularly women and disadvantaged social groups—were excluded from established public spheres.

Contemporary communication is also shaped by commercial media, digital platforms and unequal access to resources.

Nevertheless, Habermas provides an important framework for analysing **democracy, communication, public opinion and rational-critical debate**.

Key Points

Habermas's theory centres on **public discussion, communicative action and rational communication**. The public sphere provides a conceptual space for democratic debate, while communicative action explains how people can coordinate social action through mutual understanding.

IV-B. MICHEL FOUCAULT — DISCOURSE, KNOWLEDGE AND POWER

1. Introduction

Michel Foucault (1926–1984) was a French philosopher and social theorist whose work transformed sociological understandings of **power, knowledge and discourse**.

Rather than viewing power only as something possessed by governments or dominant individuals, Foucault examined how power operates through institutions, practices, knowledge and everyday relationships.

2. Discourse

A **discourse** is a historically specific system of concepts, statements and practices through which particular subjects and objects become understandable.

Discourse does not simply describe reality. It helps determine:

- what can be said;
- who can speak with authority;
- what counts as legitimate knowledge;
- how particular social problems are defined.

For example, medical discourse influences how societies understand health, illness and normality.

3. Knowledge and Power

Foucault rejects a simple separation between knowledge and power.

Power produces knowledge, and knowledge can reinforce power.

Institutions that possess authority to define legitimate knowledge can also influence how people are classified and governed.

For example, medical, educational, legal and administrative institutions classify individuals according to categories that can influence how they are treated.

4. Power Is Relational

Foucault does not treat power simply as something that one person possesses and another lacks.

Power exists within **social relationships**.

It operates through:

- institutions;
- professional practices;
- rules;
- classifications;
- surveillance;
- everyday interactions.

Power is therefore **productive as well as repressive**. It produces categories, identities, forms of knowledge and ways of behaving.

5. Discipline and Surveillance

Modern societies increasingly regulate behaviour through **disciplinary mechanisms**.

Institutions such as schools, prisons, hospitals and factories may organise:

- time;
- space;
- observation;
- examination;
- classification.

Individuals may begin to monitor their own behaviour because they know they can be observed or evaluated.

Foucault uses the idea of the **Panopticon**, associated with Jeremy Bentham's prison design, as a model for understanding this form of disciplinary power.

6. Application

Consider a school.

Students may be regulated through:

- attendance systems;
- examinations;
- grading;
- timetables;
- classroom observation;
- disciplinary rules.

These practices do not simply punish students. They also classify, measure and shape behaviour.

A Foucauldian analysis therefore asks:

How do institutional practices produce particular forms of knowledge and disciplined individuals?

7. Critical Perspective

Foucault's approach has been criticised for sometimes making power appear so widespread that it becomes difficult to identify clear sources of resistance or social transformation.

Critics also question whether his approach gives sufficient attention to economic structures and material inequalities.

Nevertheless, Foucault's major contribution is to show that **power operates through knowledge, discourse, institutions and everyday practices**, not merely through direct coercion.

Key Points

Foucault connects **discourse, knowledge and power**. His analysis shows how institutions produce knowledge and categories that shape how people understand themselves and others.

IV-C. JACQUES DERRIDA — DECONSTRUCTION

1. Introduction

Jacques Derrida (1930–2004) was a French philosopher associated with **deconstruction** and post-structuralist thought.

Although Derrida was primarily a philosopher, his ideas have influenced sociology, cultural studies and social theory.

His work questions the assumption that texts and concepts have fixed, final meanings.

---

2. Meaning and Difference

Derrida argues that meaning is produced through relationships between signs and concepts.

Words do not possess completely independent meanings. Their meanings emerge partly through their differences from other words.

For example, concepts such as:

normal/abnormal
male/female
reason/emotion
civilised/uncivilised

gain meaning partly through their relationship and contrast with one another.

---

3. Binary Oppositions

Derrida pays particular attention to **binary oppositions**.

Many systems of thought organise concepts into opposing pairs and give one side greater authority or value.

For example:

reason / emotion

may traditionally privilege reason and treat emotion as secondary.

Deconstruction examines how such oppositions are constructed and whether the supposedly superior term actually depends upon the term it excludes.

---

4. Deconstruction

Deconstruction is not simply the destruction of a text or idea.

It is a method of reading that identifies:

- assumptions;
- contradictions;
- exclusions;
- binary oppositions;
- tensions within texts and concepts.

It asks how apparently stable meanings are produced and what they leave out.

---

5. Application

Consider the distinction between **"normal" and "deviant."**

A deconstructive analysis would ask:

- Who defines normality?
- What assumptions are involved?
- What is excluded from the category of "normal"?
- Does the concept of normality depend upon the existence of deviance?
- Can the boundary between the two be as stable as it appears?

The aim is to expose the assumptions behind apparently natural categories.

---

6. Critical Perspective

Deconstruction has been criticised for making stable knowledge and meaning difficult to establish. Critics also argue that excessive attention to language and texts can distract from material conditions and social inequalities.

Its value lies in encouraging sociologists to question **apparently natural categories, fixed meanings and taken-for-granted distinctions**.

Key Points

Derrida's deconstruction examines how meanings are produced through language, difference and binary oppositions. It seeks to reveal the **assumptions, exclusions and contradictions** within apparently stable concepts.

IV-D. ANTHONY GIDDENS — STRUCTURATION

1. Introduction

Anthony Giddens (1938–) is a major British sociologist whose **theory of structuration** addresses the relationship between **structure and agency**.

A central sociological question is:

Are individuals shaped by social structures, or do individuals create and change those structures?

Giddens argues that both processes occur simultaneously.

---

2. Structure and Agency

Agency refers to the capacity of individuals to act, make choices and influence social situations.

Structure refers to the rules and resources that organise social practices.

Giddens rejects the idea that structure and agency are completely separate.

Individuals act within existing structures, but through their repeated actions they also **reproduce or transform those structures**.

---

3. Duality of Structure

The central concept of structuration theory is the **duality of structure**.

Structures are both:

- the **medium** through which social action takes place;
- the **outcome** of repeated social action.

For example, language provides rules that individuals use when communicating. At the same time, everyday use of language reproduces and sometimes changes those rules.

Thus:

Structure → enables/constrains action

and

Action → reproduces/transforms structure

---

4. Rules and Resources

Structures consist primarily of **rules and resources**.

Rules provide guidelines for behaviour, while resources give actors the capacity to exercise power and achieve outcomes.

Structures therefore do not simply constrain individuals. They can also **enable action**.

---

5. Structuration

Structuration refers to the ongoing process through which social practices are produced and reproduced across time and space.

Social life is therefore not a fixed structure. It is continuously created through human activity.

---

6. Application

Consider a university.

University rules shape student behaviour concerning:

- attendance;
- examinations;
- academic conduct.

At the same time, students and teachers reproduce these institutional arrangements through their everyday practices. If practices change significantly, institutional rules and expectations may also change.

Thus, the university is both a **structure that shapes action** and an **outcome of repeated action**.

---

7. Critical Perspective

Structuration theory is important because it avoids treating individuals as either completely free or completely determined by structures.

However, the theory has been criticised for being conceptually complex and difficult to translate into precise empirical research. Critics also debate whether Giddens gives sufficient attention to major inequalities and differences in power.

Its major contribution is the attempt to overcome the traditional opposition between **structure and agency**.

Key Points

Giddens argues that structure and agency are inseparable. Through the **duality of structure**, social actors both use existing structures and reproduce or transform them through their actions.

IV-E. PIERRE BOURDIEU — HABITUS AND CAPITAL

1. Introduction

Pierre Bourdieu (1930–2002) was a French sociologist whose work connected social structure, culture, power and individual practice.

Two central concepts are **habitus** and **capital**. Together they help explain how social inequalities are reproduced through everyday practices.

---

2. Habitus

Habitus refers to durable dispositions that individuals acquire through their social experiences.

These dispositions influence how people:

- perceive the world;
- behave;
- make choices;
- develop preferences;
- respond to situations.

Habitus is shaped by factors such as family background, education and social position.

It is neither a rigid set of rules nor a completely conscious system of choices.

3. Capital

Bourdieu extends the concept of capital beyond economic wealth.

Economic Capital

Includes money, property and other material resources.

Cultural Capital

Refers to knowledge, skills, educational qualifications, language use, cultural preferences and other culturally valued resources.

Social Capital

Refers to resources available through social relationships, networks and connections.

Symbolic Capital

Refers to forms of recognition, prestige and legitimacy that are socially valued.

Different forms of capital can be converted into one another under particular conditions.

4. Field

Another important concept is **field**.

A field is a structured social space in which individuals and groups occupy different positions and compete over valued resources.

Examples include:

- education;
- politics;
- art;
- journalism;
- academia.

What counts as valuable capital can differ from one field to another.

5. Habitus, Capital and Practice

Bourdieu explains social practice through the interaction of:

Habitus + Capital + Field → Practice

Individuals bring dispositions and resources into particular social fields. Their actions are therefore neither completely determined by social structure nor completely free choices.

6. Application

Bourdieu's theory can be applied to education.

Students from different social backgrounds may enter educational institutions with different forms of cultural capital.

For example, familiarity with academic language, communication styles, books and cultural practices may provide advantages within educational institutions.

Educational success may therefore reflect not only individual ability but also the unequal distribution of **cultural capital**.

7. Critical Perspective

Bourdieu's approach provides a powerful explanation of how inequality is reproduced through apparently ordinary practices.

However, critics argue that the concept of habitus can sometimes make individuals appear overly shaped by their social background. There is also debate about the extent to which individuals can transform their habitus and social fields.

His major contribution is to connect **culture, social structure, power and everyday practice**.

Key Points

Bourdieu explains social practice through the relationship between **habitus, capital and field**. His expanded concept of capital shows that inequality involves not only economic resources but also cultural, social and symbolic resources.

IV-F. ULRICH BECK — RISK SOCIETY

1. Introduction

Ulrich Beck (1944–2015) was a German sociologist best known for his concept of the **risk society**.

Beck argued that advanced modern societies increasingly face risks generated by the very processes of industrialisation, technological development and modernisation that were intended to improve human life.

2. Risk Society

A **risk society** is a society in which the production and management of modern risks become central social and political concerns.

Examples include:

- climate change;
- environmental pollution;
- nuclear risks;
- technological accidents;
- global financial instability;
- health and technological risks.

These risks are often difficult to predict and may cross national boundaries.

3. Reflexive Modernisation

Beck uses the idea of **reflexive modernisation** to describe a situation in which modern society increasingly becomes concerned with the unintended consequences of its own development.

Modernisation therefore produces not only wealth and opportunities but also new risks.

Society is increasingly forced to reflect upon and manage the consequences of its own technological and economic development.

4. Distribution of Risks

Traditional social inequality often concerns the distribution of **wealth and resources**.

Risk society introduces another question:

Who is exposed to risk, who produces risk and who has the resources to avoid or manage it?

Risks may cross class and national boundaries, although their effects are not necessarily equally distributed.

5. Individualisation

Beck also connects risk society with **individualisation**.

Traditional social institutions and identities become less stable, and individuals are increasingly expected to construct their own biographies and manage risks themselves.

For example, decisions concerning education, employment, relationships and career increasingly become individual responsibilities, even when they are shaped by wider structural conditions.

6. Application

Climate change is a clear example of risk society.

Modern industrial development has generated enormous economic and technological benefits but has also contributed to environmental risks.

These risks:

- cross national borders;
- involve scientific uncertainty;
- require political decisions;
- create disputes about responsibility;
- affect different groups unequally.

Risk therefore becomes a central issue of contemporary politics and social organisation.

7. Critical Perspective

Beck's theory has been criticised for sometimes presenting risks as more universally shared than they actually are. Social class, geography, gender and other inequalities influence people's exposure and ability to respond to risks.

Critics also argue that the concept may give insufficient attention to continuing forms of traditional economic inequality.

Nevertheless, risk society provides an important framework for understanding how **modernisation creates new forms of uncertainty and social conflict**.

Key Points

Beck argues that contemporary societies increasingly face risks generated by modernisation itself. **Risk society, reflexive modernisation and individualisation** are central concepts in his analysis.

IV-G. COMPARATIVE UNDERSTANDING

Thinker	Central concern	Key concepts
Habermas	Communication and democracy	Public Sphere, Communicative Action
Foucault	Discourse, knowledge and power	Discourse, Power/Knowledge, Discipline

Thinker	Central concern	Key concepts
Derrida	Meaning and language	Deconstruction, Difference, Binary Oppositions
Giddens	Structure and agency	Structuration, Duality of Structure
Bourdieu	Practice and reproduction of inequality	Habitus, Capital, Field
Beck	Risks of modernity	Risk Society, Reflexive Modernisation

These theorists approach contemporary society from different directions. Habermas focuses on **communication and democratic public debate**; Foucault examines **power and the production of knowledge**; Derrida questions apparently fixed meanings; Giddens connects **structure and agency**; Bourdieu explains the relationship between **social position, cultural resources and practice**; and Beck examines the new risks produced by modernisation.

IV-H. OVERALL CRITICAL PERSPECTIVE

Contemporary sociological theory expands the concerns of classical sociology by examining **communication, language, discourse, agency, culture, power, globalisation and new forms of risk**.

These approaches also challenge simple divisions between structure and agency. Foucault demonstrates that power operates through everyday knowledge and practices, Giddens shows how actors reproduce structures through practice, and Bourdieu explains how social dispositions and different forms of capital influence action.

At the same time, these theories have limitations. Some are highly abstract, difficult to operationalise empirically, or may underemphasise particular forms of material inequality. Their value lies in providing different conceptual tools for understanding the complexity of contemporary societies.

IV-I. OVERALL UNIT SUMMARY

Jürgen Habermas examines the conditions for democratic communication through the concepts of the **public sphere and communicative action**. His theory emphasises rational-critical discussion and the possibility of reaching mutual understanding through communication.

Michel Foucault analyses the relationship between **discourse, knowledge and power**. Power operates not only through coercion but through institutions, classifications, disciplinary practices and systems of knowledge.

Jacques Derrida's concept of **deconstruction** challenges fixed meanings and examines the assumptions, exclusions and contradictions embedded in texts and concepts.

Anthony Giddens addresses the relationship between **structure and agency** through his theory of structuration. Structures both constrain and enable action, while repeated actions reproduce or transform structures.

Pierre Bourdieu connects social structure with everyday practice through **habitus, capital and field**. His analysis shows how economic, cultural, social and symbolic resources contribute to the reproduction of inequality.

Ulrich Beck examines the consequences of modernisation through the concept of **risk society**. Contemporary societies increasingly face risks produced by technological, industrial and economic development, requiring new forms of social and political management.

The six perspectives can therefore be remembered as:

Habermas — Communication and Public Debate
Foucault — Discourse, Knowledge and Power
Derrida — Deconstruction and Meaning
Giddens — Structure and Agency
Bourdieu — Habitus, Capital and Practice
Beck — Risk and Reflexive Modernity

Together, these perspectives provide important tools for understanding **communication, power, meaning, agency, inequality and the changing risks of modern society**.

UNIT IV

1. **Discuss Jürgen Habermas' theory of communicative action and the public sphere.** Examine their significance for democracy, rational communication, and modern society.
2. **Critically examine Michel Foucault's concepts of discourse, knowledge and power.** Explain how disciplinary institutions contribute to surveillance, normalization, and social control.
3. **Explain Anthony Giddens' theory of structuration.** Discuss the relationship between structure and agency and explain the concept of the duality of structure.
4. **Discuss Pierre Bourdieu's concepts of habitus, field and different forms of capital.** Explain how these concepts help in understanding the reproduction of social inequality.
5. **Explain Ulrich Beck's concept of risk society.** Discuss the nature of modern risks and examine how globalization, technology, environmental issues, and industrial development create new forms of social risk.